



GDCAU

Green Deal for Central Asian Universities

Project 101179245

Why the European Green Deal Matters for Regenerative Futures in Central Asia

The European Green Deal (EGD) is Europe's roadmap for climate neutrality by 2050—but it also signals a global shift toward regeneration: restoring ecosystems, renewing resources, and building fairer, more resilient societies. For Central Asian students, this is more than policy—it's a call to shape the future through green, regenerative learning and careers. This guide explores how the Green Deal influences Central Asia through trade, energy, finance, and cooperation—and how you can engage in regenerative development locally.

1. Regeneration: A New Development Vision

Regeneration means going beyond sustainability: **restoring damaged ecosystems, revitalizing communities, and designing economies that give back more than they take.** It addresses root causes—like pollution, water mismanagement, and land degradation—and pursues systems change thinking, rather than just reducing harm. Central Asia urgently needs regenerative thinking: from replanting the Aral Sea's dry seabed to restoring glaciers in the Pamirs and greening industrial zones, the region must rebuild ecological and social systems together.

2. How the European Green Deal Affects Central Asia

- Through trade: The EU's Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM) pressures exporters to reduce emissions. Kazakhstan and Uzbekistan's industrial exports to the EU are already being affected. This creates demand for local expertise in carbon accounting and clean technology upgrades.
- Through standards: The EU's Green Deal includes rules on packaging, pollution, and deforestation. Central Asian producers—cotton, chemicals, metals—must meet these

standards to export. This drives demand for sustainability auditors and environmental managers.

- Through ideas and future-oriented policy models: The Green Deal is reshaping how regions imagine development—shifting from extractive growth to regeneration, fairness, and long-term resilience. As Central Asian governments study EU approaches to climate policy, just transitions, and citizen participation, the region is beginning to rethink its own social and economic futures. This creates space for students to contribute to new narratives of change—where economic diversification, community well-being, and ecological repair go hand in hand.
- Through investment: EU-backed projects like Kambarata-1 hydropower and Aral Sea reforestation show a commitment to clean energy and ecological restoration. The EU's Global Gateway aims to scale green infrastructure and nature regeneration in the region.

3. Green and Regenerative Careers Are Emerging

The green transition is creating entire ecosystems of jobs: not just in clean energy, but in restoration, sustainable farming, and policy. With international investments rising, green employment is expanding rapidly across Central Asia. The challenge is a green skills gap—students trained in regenerative systems, climate adaptation, and ESG reporting are urgently needed.

Career paths include:

- Solar and wind engineers
- Biodiversity monitoring specialists
- Green finance and ESG officers
- Water conservation and sustainable agri-tech consultants
- Environmental education and restoration coordinators
- Regenerative tourism and cultural heritage coordinators
- Ethno-biologists
- Green entrepreneurship & eco-startup founders
- Circular economy designers
- GIS and remote sensing engineers

4. What You Can Do

- Learn regenerative approaches in your degree field—whether urban design, energy systems, agriculture, or education. Use tools from the GDCAU platform.
- Join or lead campus and community sustainability efforts: eco audits, garden projects, habitat restoration, student research.
- Apply for international green fellowships, EU exchange programs, or internships on climate, energy, and sustainability.

5. Summary

Regeneration is more than the next step after sustainability—it is the future Central Asia urgently needs. The European Green Deal proves that entire regions can redesign their economies around restoration, fairness, and resilience. And Central Asia is poised to do the same. Students like you are not just observers of this transition—you are the generation who will rebuild landscapes, create green industries, and shape new social futures. The skills you develop now will define the region’s path for decades. This is your moment to step into a regenerative future with confidence, creativity, and purpose.

*Zachary Reyna
Bremen, Germany
November 2025*

Further Reading

Astana Times. “Kazakhstan Exporters Prepare for EU Carbon Border Rules at QazTrade Webinar.” *The Astana Times*, September 30, 2025. <https://astanatimes.com>.

Borrell, Josep. “EU and Central Asia: New Opportunities to Work Together for a Green Future.” *The Astana Times*, January 24, 2020. <https://astanatimes.com>.

Constructor University. “Constructor University Awarded Erasmus+ Grant for Green Deal Central Asian Universities (GDCAU) Initiative.” Constructor University News Release, November 21, 2024. <https://constructor.university>.

EEAS (European External Action Service). “European Union to Plant 27 Thousand Trees in Aral Sea Basin.” EU Delegation to Uzbekistan, April 30, 2022. <https://eeas.europa.eu>.

EEAS (European External Action Service). “Global Gateway Forum: EU Expands Investments in Hydropower to Drive Central Asia’s Energy Transformation.” October 10, 2025. <https://eeas.europa.eu>.

European Commission. *The European Green Deal*. Brussels: European Commission, 2019. <https://commission.europa.eu>.

European Environmental Bureau. *The European Green Deal – Knowledge Brief (Implications for Asia-Pacific)*. Brussels: EEB and SWITCH-Asia, 2025. <https://eeb.org>.

GIZ (Deutsche Gesellschaft für Internationale Zusammenarbeit). *Professional Green Skills for Central Asia (Project Factsheet, 2025–2028)*. Bonn and Eschborn: GIZ. <https://giz.de>.

Government of Kazakhstan. *Concept for Transition of the Republic of Kazakhstan to a Green Economy*. Astana: Government of Kazakhstan, 2013. (Job creation projection: 500,000 green jobs by 2050.) <https://www.gov.kz>.

Kun.uz. “Green Goals: How Can Uzbekistan Prepare Its Youth for a Clean Economy?”
Kun.uz, May 8, 2025. <https://kun.uz>.

Nakispekova, Aiman. “PwC Study Highlights Risks in Central Asia’s Push for Green Energy.” *The Astana Times*, September 25, 2025. <https://astanatimes.com>.

ODI (Overseas Development Institute). Borodyna, Olena. “Central Asia in Focus: What to Watch as the EU Scales Up Engagement.” ODI Insight, 2025. <https://odi.org>.

Shantayeva, Nargiz. “Assessing the Impact of the EU Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism on Kazakhstan.” *Illuminem*, September 10, 2025. <https://illuminem.com>.

UNDP Uzbekistan. “Uzbekistan and UN Partners Advance Just Energy Transition through Strategic Foresight Workshop.” UNDP Uzbekistan Press Release, September 11, 2025. <https://undp.org>.

UNICEF. “Bridging the Green Skills Gender Gap.” UNICEF Europe and Central Asia, July 15, 2025. <https://unicef.org>.